



Photo opportunity

After Nixon's Silent Majority speech on November 3, White House staff invited the press to photograph Cabinet members reading telegrams from the so-called Silent Majority. In fact, the telegrams were part of a letter-writing campaign organized by the administration.

Talking while fighting

Nixon's threats of massive bombing did not move the politburo in Hanoi, in part because it could see that the US public had turned against the war. Also, leadership in North Vietnam was in the hands of Le Duan following the death of Ho Chi Minh in September 1969.

While Ho Chi Minh had never ruled out negotiation, Duan was ruthlessly determined to win the heroic victory he thought was in sight.

Nixon and Kissinger, the global strategists, turned to Hanoi's chief patrons, Beijing and Moscow. Kissinger also undertook secret negotiations with North Vietnamese representatives in Paris, and Nixon made high-profile trips to the People's Republic of China and the Soviet Union in 1972. Despite a historic handshake with Mao Zedong in China and a nuclear arms treaty with the USSR, Nixon gained little leverage against North Vietnam from these trips.